

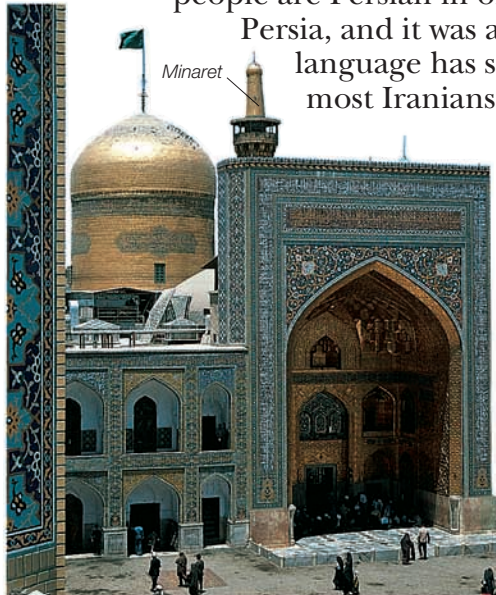


IRAN

Capital city: Tehran
Area: 636,293 sq miles (1,648,000 sq km)
Population: 68,900,000
Official language: Farsi
Major religions: Muslim 99%, other 1%
Government: Islamic republic
Currency: Iranian rial
Adult literacy rate: 77%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 2,625
Televisions: 157 per 1,000 people

IRAN

IRAN IS THE LARGEST NON-ARAB country in the Middle East; its people are Persian in origin. In ancient times, Iran was called Persia, and it was at the center of a great empire. The Persian language has survived from that time and is spoken by most Iranians. The country consists of a huge, central plateau ringed by the Zagros and Elburz mountains. In 1979, the last shah, or king, of Iran was overthrown by an Islamic revolution and the country was declared a republic. Today, oil is Iran's biggest export.



MOSQUE

Mosques are Muslim places of worship. All mosques have at least one tall tower, or minaret, from which the faithful are called to prayer. Many mosques are beautifully decorated with abstract patterns and verses from the Koran, the holy book of Islam. Artists avoid representing living things because Muslims believe nothing should be worshiped except for God, and that God is the only creator of life.



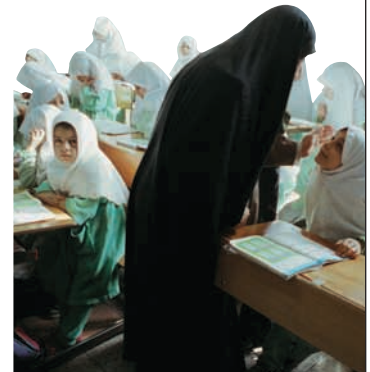
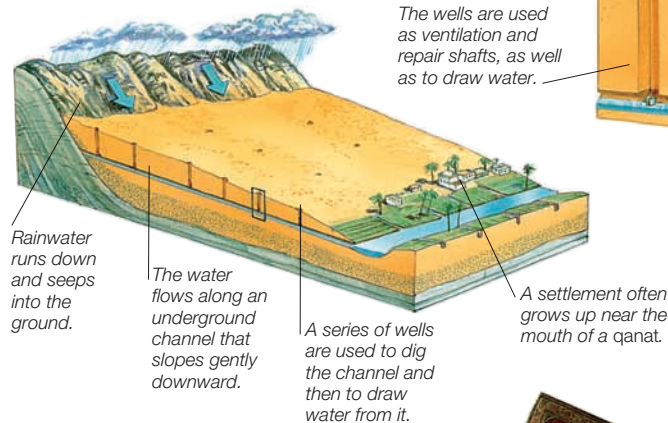
Shepherds leading their flock of sheep through the Elburz Mountains

AGRICULTURE

In recent years, Iran has tried to become less dependent on food imports and has started growing more crops, such as cereals, tea, and cotton. Herds of cattle, sheep, and goats continue to be kept by many farming families.

QANAT IRRIGATION

Less than half of the Iranian countryside is suitable for farming, and then only if it is well irrigated, or watered. Traditional irrigation methods include dams, wells, and *qanats*. A *qanat* is an underground channel that transports water from a source to an area that can be farmed. Some *qanats* are more than 25 miles (40 km) long.



A class of girls in traditional dress. In Iran girls and boys are educated separately.

THE AYATOLLAH

Ayatollah Khomeini was a key figure in the Iranian revolution and remained Iran's political and religious leader until his death in 1989. The shah had tried to introduce Western ideas to Iran, but Khomeini wanted the country to be governed by traditional Islamic laws and values. His ideas still dominate Iran.



PERSIAN CARPETS

Iran is famous for its handwoven Persian carpets. Each consists of thousands of pieces of wool knotted into elaborate patterns. The weavers always make a deliberate mistake in their work because, as Muslims, they believe that nothing is perfect except God. Carpets are Iran's second largest export, after oil.



This woman is weaving a carpet on a vertical loom.

Graceful patterns of flowers and leaves combined with abstract shapes are a feature of Persian carpets.

Find out more

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